CHAPTER 13

ONE DAY DEBUT

15 December 2002

AUSTRALIA vs ENGLAND, 2nd ODI, *Melbourne*

Australia 318/6; England 229

Australia won by 89 runs

Australia innings: **A Gilchrist b Anderson 124; J Anderson 6–0–46–1**

Inside the belly of the MCG, it feels like it is all darkness. I've been told only a few days ago by Nigel Lawton from the Academy in Adelaide that England want me to travel to join the squad. They are mid-Ashes series, having a torrid time and lots of bowlers have been sent home, injured. Nasser Hussain has only told me yesterday, to my deep surprise, that I am playing. In one sentence, spat out of his mouth, less as an honour and more as if he was recruiting to the Army, I go from a tourist to an England international.

I've waited as long as I can so as not to wake up my parents, but finally buckled at 5am, phoning home, to tell them I am going to be playing for England today. It's been only five years since the days of bunking off school to walk to the outskirts of Burnley. My parents are living in the same house as back then. I don't mention to them that I have already got the kit out of the bag and I'm wearing it in my own hotel room. I'm just looking at myself in the mirror, Vodafone emblazoned on the front of my shirt, double-checking again and again that it is real. It's like trying on an alter-ego Superman costume for the first time. It says it's medium, but it hangs off me, incredibly loose and ill-fitting. As I look at myself, I keep seeing flashes of Tom Hanks in *Big*, a child finding himself suddenly drenched in